

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: ARKANSAS TEACHER CORPS

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

On-Site Review: September 18-20, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

ARKANSAS TEACHER CORPS

ALTERNATIVE ROUTE

REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
BELOW	BELOW	BELOW
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action determination issued for this review cycle. The Division identified 12 corrective actions for this program, of which 8 are required.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Arkansas Teacher Corps
LOCATION	Fayetteville, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Educator preparation program, literacy
PATHWAY	Alternative Route
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	September 18-20, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
BELOW 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Below
Concepts of print instruction	Below
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Below
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Below
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Below
Fluency instruction	Below
Vocabulary instruction	Below
Text comprehension instruction	Below
Writing instruction	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers rated every area of study in this review area below expectations because the program offered no literacy coursework at the time of the review. The program had begun planning to deliver literacy training through LETRS beginning with the 2025 Summer Institute, but that training was not yet in place. Reviewers found no instruction covering the overview of the science of reading, concepts of print, oral language, phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics and orthography, fluency, vocabulary, text comprehension, or writing. They identified the LETRS units that would need to carry this content, including Unit 1 for Scarborough's Rope and the Simple View of Reading. Fellows also lacked exposure to high-quality instructional materials and to bridge to practice opportunities.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Create a rubric that is aligned to SOR look-fors • Align LETRS training modules across the first two years of the program • Ensure there are opportunities for fellows to make good connections to practice	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Ten of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
BELOW 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	No Rating (TOR)
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Below
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Below
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Below
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Below
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Below
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Below
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Below
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Below
Quality of written and oral feedback	Below
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers did not rate clinical placement selection because fellows serve as teachers of record, and they rated every remaining criterion below expectations. The program employed mentors only during the Summer Institute, used a mentor interview guide that contained no science of reading criteria, and could not consistently identify which fellows had mentors during the school year. The program offered no video library and no K-3 classroom observations of evidence-based literacy practice. None of the eight Summer Institute peer lessons were literacy specific. Coach training consisted of a half day on TESS with little attention to literacy or high-quality instructional materials. In observed lessons, a kindergarten reading lesson lacked explicit sequential instruction.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Create a process and criteria for selecting mentor teachers that goes beyond the state minimum, with an explicit focus on literacy experience and training • Revise training for program coaches • Enhance consistency and quality of feedback	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Five of the twelve corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
BELOW 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Below
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Approaching
Quality of monitoring	Approaching
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Below
Quality improvement planning	Below
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Below
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that the program collected general data through surveys, TESS evaluations, coaching cycles, Praxis results, and its licensure tracker, but gathered no literacy-specific data tied to the science of reading and used no literacy-specific observation tool. Fellow support plans operated at programmatic, growth, and transitional levels, and reviewers rated these internal checkpoints and the program's monitoring as approaching expectations while noting that no support plan trigger involved literacy instruction or literacy data. The program had no formalized improvement plan. Written feedback arrived on multiple inconsistent forms and emphasized teacher actions over student outcomes. Reviewers also found no formal requirement that partner districts supply high-quality instructional materials.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Improve data collection and utilization • Revise surveys to include literacy-specific criteria from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework • Revise summer institute and professional development sessions to incorporate framework literacy criteria • Monitor and adjust	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
One of the twelve corrective actions targets this review area.	

CORRECTIVE ACTION

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education issues a corrective action determination. The Division selects from a standard set of corrective actions and marks each one required or recommended for the program. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the actions below are what the Division has directed the program to do.

ACTIONS IDENTIFIED	REQUIRED	RECOMMENDED
12	8	4

The Division identified 12 corrective actions for this program, 8 required and 4 recommended. Required actions must be completed. Recommended actions are directed to the program as supports for the same findings. Some actions address more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS REQUIRED TO TAKE

CORRECTIVE ACTION	REVIEW AREA ADDRESSED	DESIGNATION	EVIDENCE REQUIRED
LETRS training or equivalent	RA1	REQUIRED	LETRS training certificates
RISE training, proficiency pathway	RA1	RECOMMENDED	RISE training certificates
Walk-through tool training	RA2	REQUIRED	Walk-through tool training certificates
Course revisions	RA1	REQUIRED	Revised course syllabi and observations
Cognitive coaching training	RA2	REQUIRED	Cognitive coaching training certificate
Inclusive practices training	RA1, RA2	RECOMMENDED	Inclusive practices training certificate
Full program revision	RA1-3	REQUIRED	Complete program revision submitted to Educator Preparation; interim visit
Defined partnerships and collaboration with dyslexia specialists at education cooperatives	RA1	REQUIRED	Certificate of completion from Southeast, Great Rivers, or Crowley's Ridge cooperative
Lesson plan internalization training (TNTP)	RA1	RECOMMENDED	Training certificate
Identify the HQIM in all partner districts and incorporate it into revised coursework	RA1	REQUIRED	Matrix of partner district HQIM and its inclusion in coursework
Small group instruction training, K-2 and 3-6	RA1, RA2	RECOMMENDED	Training certificate; participation through DESE and/or cooperatives
Literacy Foundations for English Learners book study (Elsa Cardenas-Hagan)	RA1	REQUIRED	Book study notes as documentation

OVERSIGHT

Each corrective action carries an evidence requirement, shown above. The program supplies the person responsible, the timeline for completion, and how each action will be used in the program when it submits its

corrective action plan to the Division. Those execution details are not recorded in the determination and are therefore not published here.

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, Arkansas Teacher Corps, September 18-20, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). Arkansas Teacher Corps Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.